

VERSION 26.01 · JUNE 2026 · A FULL REWRITE

Generative AI in K-12 Education

Guidance for Arizona Schools and School Systems

A Call for AI Literacy

A companion one-pager: **what changed** in the 2026 rewrite, plus a **role-based reading route** for each leader. Page numbers reference v26.01 — read the full document at azk12.ai.



What changed in 2026

From “A Balanced Perspective” to “A Call for AI Literacy” — the ten shifts that matter most.

BIG PICTURE

p Cover & throughout

A full rewrite, not a refresh

Version 26.01 is explicitly a rewrite and shifts the public frame from “A Balanced Perspective” to “A Call for AI Literacy.”

Why: Lead with optimism: Arizona isn’t just reacting to AI — it’s helping leaders build literacy, judgment, and human agency.

AI LITERACY

p 22–23

AI literacy becomes the center of gravity

AI literacy is treated as a core, cross-disciplinary competency connected to AZ Academic Standards and the State 48 Essential Skills.

Why: It gives curriculum and leadership teams a concrete instructional anchor.

EXPLAINER**p 8–9****Understanding GenAI is modernized**

The explainer now covers multimodal tools, reasoning models, agentic AI, model limitations, and the “chef” analogy for how outputs are shaped.

Why: Leaders need enough technical understanding to decide well — without becoming AI engineers.

GUARDRAILS**p 10–20****Ethics moves earlier and expands**

Responsible and Ethical Implementation now appears before the teaching chapter and expands from five considerations to eight.

Why: Safety, trust, privacy, and human oversight become the entry point, not an afterthought.

NEW SECTIONS**p 17–19****Three new ethical considerations**

Mental Well-Being (p. 17), Environmental Impact (p. 18), and Cybersecurity (p. 19) are added as explicit considerations.

Why: The guidance now reflects the AI realities schools are actually facing in 2026.

PRIVACY**p 14–15****Privacy becomes more sophisticated**

Privacy guidance now includes the illusion of privacy in chatbot interactions and the data authority of Arizona's 22 sovereign tribal nations.

Why: It strengthens the document for district policy, vendor review, and community trust.

TEACHING AND LEARNING**p 26–28****Classroom guidance matures beyond cheating**

Academic integrity broadens into responsible classroom use: cognitive offloading, grading and feedback, disclosure, and AI detectors.

Why: It helps educators design learning instead of simply policing tools.

Teaching points toward redesign

The new “AI Inspiration” section invites authentic creation, inquiry, community-connected work, portfolios, and exhibitions.

Why: The optimistic heart of the update: AI can push schools toward learning we already value.

Administrative use becomes clearer

School & Administrative Use now separates enhancing existing work from transforming workflows, including agentic AI.

Why: It gives non-classroom leaders a thoughtful path into AI productivity without losing human judgment.

Implementation gets Arizona-specific

The old stage model becomes a “boat” framework: local pacing, shared leadership, the 3 essentials, policy and guidelines, and ongoing learning.

Why: It makes implementation feel achievable, flexible, and grounded in local context.

Your reading route, by role

Everyone starts the same place — Introduction (p. 6) and Understanding GenAI (pp. 8–9) — then follows their route.

Superintendent & Cabinet

25–35 min · District vision, public trust, and implementation momentum

● Read first

Introduction & Orientation	p. 6
Understanding GenAI	p. 8–9
The Imperative: AI Literacy & State 48 alignment	p. 22–23
Conclusion & Next Steps (the big picture)	p. 37

● Read next, if time

Implementation Recommendations	p. 32–36
Responsible & Ethical overview + Addressing Considerations	p. 10, 20

“What position statement would help our community understand why we’re moving forward thoughtfully — and how AI literacy connects to the State 48 Graduate Profile?”

Curriculum & Instruction

40–50 min · AI literacy, instructional design, assessment, and academic integrity

● Read first

Understanding GenAI	p. 8–9
Powerful Teaching and Learning	p. 21–29
The Imperative: AI Literacy table	p. 22–23

● Read next, if time

Responsible & Ethical Implementation	p. 10–20
Responsible Classroom Use	p. 26–28

“Which learning tasks should AI support, and which thinking must remain visibly human?”

EdTech & Instructional Coaches

45–60 min · Practical adoption, teacher support, approved tools, and PD

● Read first

Understanding GenAI p. 8–9

Powerful Teaching and Learning p. 21–29

Implementation Recommendations p. 32–36

● Read next, if time

Additional Resources: AI literacy & PD p. 38

School & Administrative Use p. 30–31

“What reusable models, examples, and guardrails help educators move from fear or novelty to purposeful use?”

IT, Cybersecurity & Data Privacy

30–45 min · Data protection, cybersecurity, vendor review, and agentic risk

● Read first

Understanding GenAI (esp. agentic AI) p. 8–9

Data and Information Privacy p. 14–15

Cybersecurity p. 19

Addressing Ethical Considerations p. 20

● Read next, if time

School & Administrative Use risks p. 30–31

Implementation: approved tools & policy p. 34–36

“Where do permissions, integrations, and data exposure create the highest risk?”

Principal & Site Administrator

30–40 min · School norms, staff clarity, classroom use, and family trust

● Read first

Introduction & Orientation	p. 6
Understanding GenAI	p. 8–9
Responsible Classroom Use	p. 26–28
School and Administrative Use	p. 30–31

● Read next, if time

Responsible & Ethical Implementation	p. 10–20
Implementation: 3ssentials & guidelines	p. 34–36

“What common expectations would reduce confusion for teachers, students, and families?”

Operations, HR & Finance

20–30 min · Workflow enhancement, multilingual communication, and human oversight

● Read first

Understanding GenAI	p. 8–9
School and Administrative Use	p. 30–31
Data and Information Privacy	p. 14–15

● Read next, if time

Cybersecurity	p. 19
Implementation Recommendations	p. 32–36

“Which workflow has clear rules, repeated steps, and low-risk data where AI could safely help?”

Teachers

30–45 min · Instructional practice, student agency, and responsible use

● Read first

Teacher Use Cases	p. 24
Student Use Cases	p. 25
Responsible Classroom Use	p. 26–28
The Redesign: AI Inspiration	p. 29

● Read next, if time

Understanding GenAI	p. 8–9
Responsible & Ethical overview	p. 10

“How can AI be a coach or thought partner without becoming an assignment’s easy button?”

An unofficial reading guide to Arizona's 2026 GenAI guidance (v26.01), 41 pages. Page numbers reference that edition; always read the live document at azk12.ai. Produced by the Arizona Institute for Education & the Economy companion project · June 2026.